New Digital Recruitment Techniques: A Case Study from Mathura

To understand what this expansion meant for the lowest rung of the BJP, I travelled to Mathura in July 2020. COVID-19 cases were surging across UP. Wearing face masks and fortified by the feverish use of hand-sanitisers, I visited the office of a local BJP municipality parshad (councillor) to meet with half a dozen senior local party functionaries. We chatted over sumptuous helpings of ghevar (a traditional milk dessert), milky tea and biscuits. The party's Mathura unit had claimed as many as 1 million new members in the recent membership drive—among the highest enrolment numbers in UP. For a district with a total population of 2.5 million (Census of India, 2011), it was an astoundingly large figure. I asked my hosts—all dedicated BJP karyakartas of over two decades' standing—how they enrolled members, how was it different from before, how accurate these numbers were and what it meant for their daily work as political workers. Their answers were eye-opening.

Figure 8.4: Narendra Modi and the BJP Far Bigger than RSS on Social Media Platforms in 2020